Chapter One: The Lighthouse

Maren took the ferry to the island on the first morning of spring.
The lighthouse keeper had retired in winter, and nobody had replaced him.
She found the logbook open on the desk, its last entry dated the night of the storm.
Every page recorded the same ritual: trim the wick, wind the clockwork, note the wind.
By noon she had cleaned the lens and discovered that the clockwork still turned.
That evening the light swept the bay for the first time in four months.

Chapter Two: The Logbook

The entries grew shorter toward the end, as if the keeper had been saving ink.
One line mentioned a boat that passed too close to the rocks and never answered the horn.
Maren compared the dates with the harbor records and found the boat had been reported missing.
She wrote her own first entry that night, copying the ritual word for word.
The wind was from the north, the lens was clean, and the light did not fail.
In the morning she radioed the harbor to say the lighthouse was keeping watch again.